strategically speaking – it was worst of all for the Serbs. (What would have happened had the Serbs, instead of opting for violent nationalism, put themselves at the front of an all-Yugoslav, genuinely democratic movement which favoured federalism, thus preserving Yugoslavia?) They paid a high price and, until after the fall of Milošević, they were excluded from the European Union's plans for the Balkans, being overtaken by Bosnia and Herzegovina, North Macedonia and Montenegro. This past mistake continues to trouble Serbia, as does its – almost exclusively emotional – attachment to Russia. Well, sometimes it pays off when it comes to gas.

Only after arms were finally laid down with the NATO intervention in Serbia and Kosovo in 1999, and United Nations administration was imposed in Kosovo the very same year, were efforts begun on the side of the Balkan nations and Brussels to allow them gradually back into the political realm of Eastern Europe by putting them on the EU track.[21] More than 20 years later the process is more or less at the beginning, due to both lack of inner capacities of the countries concerned and absence of true enthusiasm on the part of the Western European electorate, in particular in France and the Netherlands.

But let's return to the fifteenth century! While the Balkans were being conquered by the Ottomans, the Central European part of Eastern Europe, through its early adoption of Western Christianity and through its contact with the Germanic world, managed to maintain its inclusion in the Western world. It enjoyed relative political stability and the vicinity of the economic axis of Europe. Nations further east were at a lower socio-economic stage of development (for reasons explained earlier), while nations under Ottoman rule lost contact with mainstream Europe to a high degree.

The Ottoman era in Europe is also the time when the term 'Eastern Europe' was coined. According to Wolff,[22] the modern concept of Eastern Europe originates in the attempts of eighteenth-century philosophers to find a physical location for the state of mind they considered opposite to that of the Enlightenment. Although they believed so deeply in the importance of reasoning and empirical evidence, the key figures in this process, Voltaire and Rousseau, seem never to have actually visited Eastern Europe. Further handicapped by the embryonic state of the geographical and linguistic sciences of the time, their accounts suggested a place of uniform and unvarying poverty, backwardness, ruthlessness and dullness – a vision that